

MODDABLE CHESS · VARIANT 43 OF 64

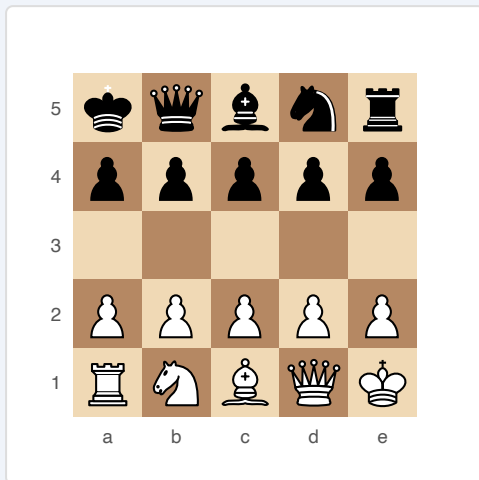
# Minichess

**5×5**  
BOARD

**2**  
PLAYERS

# MINICHESS

Gardner's 5×5 chess. All standard piece types on a tiny board. Fast, tactical, and surprisingly deep for its size.



Minichess — starting position (5×5)

## SETUP

**Board:** 5×5 (five files, five ranks).

**Setup (FEN):** kqbnr/ppppp/5/PPPPP/RNBQK

Black (rank 5): King, Queen, Bishop, Knight, Rook (+ 5 pawns on rank 4). White (rank 1): Rook, Knight, Bishop, Queen, King (+ 5 pawns on rank 2).

## RULES

- ♦ Standard chess movement for all pieces.
- ♦ Pawns move one square forward only (no double-step).
- ♦ No en passant.
- ♦ No castling (King and Rook are adjacent — no room to castle).
- ♦ Pawns promote on the far rank to Queen, Rook, Bishop, or Knight.

## WIN CONDITION

Checkmate, same as standard chess.

## STRATEGY

The tiny board means pieces are immediately in contact. Rooks are less powerful (short files) while Knights are relatively stronger (they can reach most of the board in 1-2 moves). Games are decided quickly — material advantages of even a single pawn are usually decisive. The King is very exposed with so few squares to hide. Queen trades simplify the position enormously.

## ATTRIBUTION

Martin Gardner, 1969 (Scientific American). Public domain.